

SUPPLEMENT: THE IMPORTANCE OF REGISTER IN ENGLISH

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Read the following text and for each of the blank spaces (1 - 36) choose the correct answer (a, b, c or d) from those listed at the bottom of each page. **CIRCLE** your answer (a, b, c or d).

Language register is the scale of formality we use when we write and speak. Think about the differences in the way you communicate with your boss, doctor, teacher, classmates, friends, or even your pet. What (1) _____ the difference in (2) _____ you communicate in these situations is your formality register.

THE MAIN REGISTERS IN ENGLISH

Register in linguistics is divided (3) _____ six levels describing different types of register or formality definitions in writing and speaking. The main registers in English are high formal, formal, neutral, informal, vulgar, and static. These are also sometimes called address registers because we use them to address (4) _____ in different situations in life as a speaker or writer.

Registers work to increase the variety of a language as well as the appropriateness of writing and speaking. The term register also defines the differences between when, why, and (5) _____ we use formal or informal language in our day-to-day lives. Writers adapt their language to suit the purpose and their audience. A writer can use a high register (formal) or low register (informal) language, depending on the situation.

The choice of register affects the tone of the writing and (6) _____ the reader perceives it. Examples of high(er) register language might include academic papers, legal documents, certain types of letters / emails and business reports. Low register language includes text messages, social media posts, and casual emails to friends.

The most important point to remember is that you (7) _____ never mix formal and informal registers. You can refer to the table below to ensure that you stay in your selected level of formality.

(8) _____ there are some minor differences in register between United States and British English, the basic rules of maintaining register are relatively consistent across all forms of English.

THE SIX ENGLISH LANGUAGE REGISTER DEFINITION LEVELS

There are six main types of English register we use in writing and speaking. We use them to maintain a consistently appropriate register in different aspects of our daily life.

1) HIGH FORMAL

This is the level of language (9) _____ you would use in spoken English on very formal occasions; for example, to address the Queen, an archbishop, president, or prime minister. It is also often used in legal correspondence, proceedings, and especially in a court of law.

- | | | | | |
|-----|------------|-----------|------------|----------------|
| (1) | a) gives | b) makes | c) does | d) starts |
| (2) | a) how | b) way | c) however | d) the way how |
| (3) | a) up | b) in | c) by | d) into |
| (4) | a) persons | b) people | c) peoples | d) the people |
| (5) | a) how | b) way | c) however | d) the way how |
| (6) | a) how | b) way | c) however | d) the way how |
| (7) | a) shall | b) not | c) should | d) ever |
| (8) | a) Despite | b) While | c) However | d) But |
| (9) | a) , that | b) what | c) that | d) when |

Please note that pronouns are used throughout this text – that is because this is from an online article. Online articles & websites often use personal pronouns and less formal language because they want to make a personal connection with the reader – ACADEMIC TEXTS ARE MEANT TO BE OBJECTIVE, NOT PERSONAL; therefore, pronouns are rarely used and more formal language is both preferred and expected. NOTE – you should be aware of the differences between spoken and written English

FEATURES OF SPOKEN ENGLISH:

- informal
- simple
- rhythm
- use of slang and colloquialism
- narrative form (based on actions/events)

FEATURES OF WRITTEN ENGLISH:

- permanent
- explicit
- dense (more grammatically complex)
- detached (objective)
- organized

2) FORMAL

You would use Formal language when you speak or write to your boss, a client, a teacher or write a transactional letter and/or email. It should also be used when you speak or write to (10) _____ you have never met and/or do not know very well.

The formal language definition is sometimes called the consultative register. You use it when, for example, you are referring (11) _____ or talking to your doctor and using the polite address of Dr.

Formal register (12) _____ uses the passive voice to avoid attribution, fault, or responsibility – however, it is not overly or exclusively used (as it generally is in Neutral register)

3) NEUTRAL

Neutral register is a formal or conventional language level you would use in transactional situations. These (13) _____ include business letters, report writing, business plans, marketing presentations, or speaking to a client. The difference between Formal & Neutral register here is that quite often, in business, communication is on a less formal level because people are trying to build (and/or already have) a relationship.

NOTE – the purpose of academic texts and/or papers is NOT meant to build a relationship – their purpose is to communicate information clearly and objectively.

Neutral register often uses the passive voice to avoid attribution, fault, or responsibility.

4) INFORMAL (aka CASUAL)

You use informal or casual register when you speak to or write emails and messages to friends, family, classmates or work colleagues.

5) VULGAR (aka INTIMATE)

The vulgar definition is not the language of a dirty joke.

(from the Cambridge Dictionary: vulgar [adjective - UK /'vʌl.gər/ US /'vʌl.gə-/] not suitable, simple, dignified or beautiful)

This intimate register refers (14) _____ the type of language we use when we talk to immediate or to (15) _____ family members, very close friends, a child, or a family pet. This is also the type of language used in text messages and/or other social media-type postings.

6) FROZEN or STATIC REGISTER

Although not always recognized, this is (16) _____ form of register. It is language use that does not change (17) _____ custom or etiquette, particularly in printed or often repeated form.

Examples of frozen register include biblical quotations, oaths of office, prayers, or pledges of allegiance.

ENGLISH REGISTER AND THE 'YOU' PROBLEM

Unlike many Latin languages, which have dedicated formal and informal subject pronoun and verb conjugations, register in English uses a (18) _____ more complex array of vocabulary and grammar structures to govern register.

In French, for instance, these two phrases that ask “how are you?” clearly identify formality because French has two forms of the second person subject pronoun, you.

- **Vous** allez bien? **FORMAL**
- **Tu** vas bien? **INFORMAL**

The first is **formal** using **vous** and would be appropriate with people (19) _____ are not close friends, such as superiors, acquaintances, and strangers.

The second is **informal** using **tu**, which is fitting with family, close friends, and children.

In English, however, we (20) _____ have one second-person subject pronoun, which is **you** (regardless of whether it is singular or plural).

Please note that the word 'you' is only capitalized (i.e., 'You') when it is the first word in a sentence ('You' DOES NOT indicate formality in English).

- | | | | | |
|------|---------------|---------------|--------------|-----------------|
| (10) | a) someone | b) the one | c) some one | d) them |
| (11) | a) by | b) to | c) at | d) on |
| (12) | a) some times | b) sometime | c) sometimes | d) some-of-time |
| (13) | a) could | b) need | c) shall | d) ought |
| (14) | a) by | b) to | c) at | d) on |
| (15) | a) near | b) convenient | c) nearest | d) close |
| (16) | a) other | b) the other | c) another | d) an other |
| (17) | a) thanks to | b) as result | c) due to | d) considering |
| (18) | a) far | b) farther | c) further | d) furthest |
| (19) | a) , who | b) who | c) , that | d) which |
| (20) | a) solely | b) just | c) hardly | d) only |

HOW DO YOU USE AND CONTROL REGISTER AND FORMALITY CONSISTENTLY IN ENGLISH?

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We control language register, or formality definition, (21) _____ using three language points.

Register in English uses grammar, vocabulary, and punctuation. These elements are (22) _____ to all linguistic varieties of English register.

The table below (23) _____ the key differences between the basic formal and informal registers.

HIGH FORMAL	FORMAL	NEUTRAL	INFORMAL	VULGAR	FROZEN/STATIC
Register in English					
Formal Features			Informal Features		
Vocabulary Items					
Latin and French based words Uncommon words			Anglo Saxon words and phrasal verbs Common words		
Punctuation					
Full words			Abbreviations Contractions		
Grammar					
Passive constructions Noun phrases Complex sentences Indirect Questions			Active constructions Verb phrases Simple sentences Direct Questions		

EXPLANATION OF REGISTER IN WRITING AND SPEAKING

VOCABULARY

(24) _____ centuries in Britain, Anglo-Norman French was the language in everyday use by the aristocracy, law courts, formal education in schools and universities, and some sections of the gentry. Latin was the language of business and the church.

(25) _____ that time, English was the language of the common people. (26) _____ this history of language in Britain, French, and to a lesser extent, Latin have both remained integrated with modern English. Therefore, the choice of words and verbs, in particular, based (27) _____ their etymology, governs modern English registers.

Latin and French-based verbs are always one full word, quite long, and are generally used in formal writing and speaking. Most single-word Anglo-Saxon verbs are recognizably very short. Think about *to do*, *to hit*, *to put*, *to look*, *to give*, *to run*, and *to jump*. These are informal.

English phrasal verbs are always a short root verb plus one or two particles (28) _____ are mostly prepositions. Examples are, *give up*, *call in*, *take off* and *get on with*.

If we take a few Latin and French-based verbs, such as *to receive*, *to purchase*, *to comprehend*, *to appreciate*, *to tolerate*, *to schedule*, *to consider*, *to approve*, and *to accommodate*, they are noticeably much longer. These formal verbs would be replaced in informal register (29) _____ *to get*, *to buy*, *to get*, *to like*, *to put up with*, *to set up*, *to think about*, *to okay*, and *to put up*.

Common and uncommon words are often words such as linking words. *And*, *but* and *so* are informal, *while* *furthermore*, *however*, and *therefore* are the formal equivalents.

- | | | | | |
|------|--------------|--------------|-------------|----------------|
| (21) | a) via | b) with | c) by | d) on |
| (22) | a) regular | b) common | c) usual | d) classical |
| (23) | a) shows | b) shows us | c) informs | d) explains us |
| (24) | a) For | b) During | c) In | d) At |
| (25) | a) While | b) During | c) By | d) However |
| (26) | a) Thanks to | b) As result | c) In spite | d) Because of |
| (27) | a) with | b) to | c) on | d) from |
| (28) | a) , which | b) which | c) , that | d) what |
| (29) | a) of | b) for | c) at | d) with |

WHAT IS VULGAR LANGUAGE OR VOCABULARY?

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Examples of common or vulgar words and expressions are, 'ta' for thank you, 'ta-ta' for goodbye, 'tummy' for the stomach, and 'belly button' for the navel. This also includes non-standard forms of words such as 'gonna', 'gotta', and 'wanna'.

For vocabulary register, you can use this general rule. You would use long words and verbs if you are wearing formal attire and you attend a formal dinner or formal garden party. However, you would use short words that are informal when (30) _____ with friends or family at a picnic.

PUNCTUATION

Register punctuation is the use of contraction and abbreviation both in writing and speaking. Without contractions or abbreviations, it is formal language, and with all contractions and abbreviations, it is informal.

While *asap*, *memo* and *HQ* are informal because they are abbreviations, *as soon as possible*, *memorandum* and *headquarters* are formal because they are written or (31) _____ in full.

As for contraction, when speaking to a friend, one might say, "*I wouldn't've baked a cake if I'd known you weren't coming.*" But if you use this phrase when speaking to your boss, it would change to the formal structure of, "*I would not have arranged the meeting if I had known you would not be available.*"

GRAMMAR

The structures noted above are mostly self-explanatory. But the ones (32) _____ do need a little explanation are noun and verb phrases.

Simply put, a noun phrase uses an object as the subject of a phrase and not a subject pronoun or name.

Often this results in creating the passive voice. For instance:

- | | |
|--|----------|
| • Joe and Charles attended the meeting. | INFORMAL |
| • The meeting was attended by Joe and Charles. | FORMAL |
| • Joe and Charles thought the meeting was a success. | INFORMAL |
| • The meeting was thought to have been a success. | FORMAL |
| • Robert Mortimer built the house in 1789. | INFORMAL |
| • The house was built in 1789 by Robert Mortimer. | FORMAL |

(33) _____ important grammar point is in constructing correct indirect questions.

You should always (34) _____ care to ensure that you use only one question structure in the complete phrase. This always means structuring the first verb phrase as the question and the second verb phrase in statement order. It is a common cause of grammar mistakes.

(35) _____ the two examples below, the first moves the verb **to be**. In the second, the auxiliary **do** drops in the indirect or polite question form.

- | | |
|--|--|
| • What is your name? | THIS IS A DIRECT <u>INFORMAL</u> QUESTION |
| • Could you please tell me what your name is? | THIS IS AN INDIRECT <u>FORMAL</u> QUESTION |
| • Do you have time for a quick chat? | THIS IS A DIRECT <u>INFORMAL</u> QUESTION |
| • I was wondering if you have time for a quick discussion? | THIS IS AN INDIRECT <u>FORMAL</u> QUESTION |

Inversion sentences and clauses are also quite common in formal writing but are rare in any form of informal discourse.

On the other (36) _____, question tags are always informal (e.g., *You live in San Francisco, **don't you?***).

- | | | | | |
|------|-----------------|-----------------|---------------|---------------|
| (30) | a) conversating | b) conversation | c) conversing | d) conversion |
| (31) | a) told | b) asked | c) said | d) requested |
| (32) | a) , that | b) what | c) , which | d) that |
| (33) | a) The other | b) Other | c) Another | d) Some other |
| (34) | a) take | b) give | c) be | d) have |
| (35) | a) With | b) In | c) During | d) By |
| (36) | a) side | b) foot | c) way | d) hand |

HIGHLIGHTING THE DIFFERENCES IN LANGUAGE REGISTER FORMALITY

When you learn how to write a formal letter, there are several conventions you need to follow.

With formal letter writing (which includes emails) you know that you should write *Dear Sir or Madam* before the first paragraph of your letter and *Yours sincerely* or *Yours faithfully* at the end.

When it comes to writing the letter, the body of the text will use register to control formal writing. It applies to any form of communication, both in writing and orally.

There are two example forms of a letter on the following page. Both cover the same subject matter but are in different registers.

Compare the changes from the first letter to the second letter to understand how the formality differs with the use of grammar, vocabulary, and punctuation.

EXAMPLE FORMAL LETTER

⚡ Please note that 'Dear Mr. or Mrs.' is NOT English

Dear Sir / Madam,

⚡ Please note that the phrase 'I hope this letter finds you well' is NOT USED HERE

I am writing to thank you for the letter we received on the 14th of September 2018.

⚡ NOTE: Most formal letters begin with WHY YOU ARE WRITING.

A copy has been sent to company headquarters in addition to a memorandum concerning your financial situation.

Introducing yourself is not truly necessary as you will state your name at the end.

A meeting has been scheduled for the 3rd October 2018 at 11 am to discuss your request for a further bank loan. Therefore, please inform us of your availability for this meeting at the earliest opportunity.

ALSO – please note that PARAGRAPHS are used.

However, a number of issues concerning your income and expenditure may be queried prior to a loan being granted.

Furthermore, the General Manager needs to be contacted in order to authorize bank loans of this nature. Moreover, your previous failure to meet payment arrangements will first have to be considered.

Nevertheless, in the interim, you are required to complete the enclosed business plan, which should be brought to the meeting.

Yours sincerely

FULL NAME

EXAMPLE INFORMAL LETTER

Hello,

Thanks for your letter. We got it on 14 Sept.

We've sent a copy to comp. H.Q. along with a memo re. your financial situation. I've set a meeting for 3 Oct at 11 am to talk about another bank loan.

So, please let us know if you can make it a.s.a.p. But, we might ask you a few things to do with your inc. and exp. before giving you a loan.

Also, I gotta get in touch with the G.M. to okay it.

Plus, we'll first have to think about the last time you didn't keep up with your payments. Anyway, in the meantime, you need to fill in this business plan. Bring it to the meeting with you.

Have a nice day.

⚡ Many students who read this may find this 'informal example' humorous, or perhaps ridiculous . . .

HOWEVER – this example is closer to what the majority of students are able to produce than the 'formal example' above.

THE FORMAL LETTER WRITING OPTION HAS BEEN REMOVED FROM THE FEL B2 ENGLISH EXAM